

Episode 169: Summer Greetings and Current Status

Summer greetings to you all. How are you spending these hot summer days?

Recently, I've been dropping manuscripts sporadically - no, completely - and I'm sorry (sweat).

I'm currently in the midst of production for Director Ikuhara Kunihiro's long-awaited new work, TV animation *Mawaru Penguindrum* currently airing to great acclaim on MBS network, spending enjoyable passionate days every day and night. Broadcasting has already finished through Episode 5. After a break for golf broadcast(!), from this weekend's Episode 6, turbulent broadcasting continues. All 24 episodes, broadcast until year-end.

My recent daily routine involves commuting from my home in Nakano to Mitaka via Chuo Line. Amazingly, a commuter pass! I haven't had a commuter pass for about 10 years? But this is cheapest and most convenient. I can stop at Kichijoji freely along the way (laugh).

Such Chuo Line commuting - after arriving at Mitaka Station, I first stop at Starbucks in the station building for coffee. I carry around a 16-ounce, exactly "Grande" size thermal bottle, buying coffee for it before heading to the studio as daily routine. Usually hot coffee, but this summer, naturally iced coffee. This thermal bottle is quite good - stays properly cold for about half a day. Ice remains unmelted, which makes me happy.

Going daily, shop staff gradually remember my face, which feels nice too.

About a 5-minute walk from the south exit to Brain's Base, the production company with staff rooms. Stopping at convenience stores along the way is also routine. Here I buy mineral water. Brand: Wilkinson. Carbonated mineral water.

When travelling in Europe, mineral water sold in cities is usually carbonated, and being somewhat uncomfortable with carbonation, I avoided gas-filled ones completely, but apparently this carbonation somewhat helps relax muscles and shoulder stiffness, so hearing that rumour, I thought "well then..." and started drinking it. As rumoured, it might be somewhat good. So I continue drinking it. The sharp taste feels good too. Well, regarding shoulder stiffness, I'm simultaneously taking Vitamin B12 supplements, so that might be helping, but I think it's good to try anything possible.

Though the biggest enemy is undeniably lack of exercise...

I buy two 500ml bottles of that Wilkinson. Depending on timing, I also buy rice balls, sandwiches, lunch boxes. Oh yes, I often buy Calorie Mate too. Fruit and Maple are recent favourites. Perfect for eating when slightly hungry during studio work.

"This isn't very delicious, so it's just right!" says Chief Director Nakamura Akiko-san. She apparently often buys Calorie Mate too. "Because if it were delicious, you'd eat too much!" Ah, certainly (bitter laugh).

Brain's Base building is located slightly into a residential area from the commercial district. Since staff rooms are on upper floors, I unhesitatingly take the elevator (laugh). Eh? Stairs? Lack of exercise? ...No no (bitter laugh).

This building's stairs are outside stairs, and previously when I went up by stairs, the floor entrance was locked and I couldn't enter, waiting 1.5 hours for staff to arrive, so since then it's basically elevator.

Mawaru Penguindrum's staff room isn't that spacious. Desks are arranged everywhere with shoulder-width narrow passages like a maze (laugh). During the recent big earthquake, colour boxes stacked on animation desks fell simultaneously! During continued aftershocks, everyone couldn't restack colour boxes in original locations for a while, making narrow passages even narrower with colour boxes.

My seat is the northwest corner of the staff room. I work with colour direction staff in an area half-covered by black light-blocking material. Since I use my monitor as the reference monitor, various checks like art boards, backgrounds, character colour checks are usually done at my seat. When there's lots to check, it's tough and I often can't do my own work. Well, either way, I need to attend those checks, so time consumption is unavoidable (laugh).

Furthermore, I attend many meetings. Regarding each episode's meetings: starting with "direction meetings" held immediately after storyboard completion, "art board meetings" for art board orders, "art meetings" following that episode's overall art flow, "colour direction meetings" between assigned colour direction staff and myself based on colour direction charts I write, and "photography meetings" with photography staff about screen processing. These happen once weekly without fail.

And furthermore, all-rushes & retake assignments happen weekly without fail. To complete and deliver one episode weekly, you must clear things one by one weekly. If this starts stalling for any reason, the ripple effects are quite large and returning to track becomes difficult.

With so much to do plus handling individual episode colour direction beyond colour design duties, my own work inevitably becomes late-night work. Since meetings and various checks often happen late at night, it becomes late-night work tendency anyway, making dawn returns routine.

Originally a morning person, once entering TV work rhythm, I can't maintain morning routines. Forcing it eliminates sleep time. So recently I've completely given up - first train home → morning sleep. Well, when I can go home at night, I properly go home. Then get up again and commute to Mitaka via Chuo Line (laugh).

This is roughly my recent daily routine and current status. Such days will continue until year-end. Gradually settling as life rhythm. Around 4:30 AM when Mitaka Station's first up-train departs, it was completely bright with risen sun around summer solstice, but recently it's still dimly dark before sunrise. Definitely the latter half of this year. Just one more month until autumn equinox.

Making *Mawaru Penguindrum* like this - everyone please treat us favourably (laugh).

(11.08.16)